



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

PUBLIC SPEAKING

Lecture 30: Debates

Prof. Binod Mishra

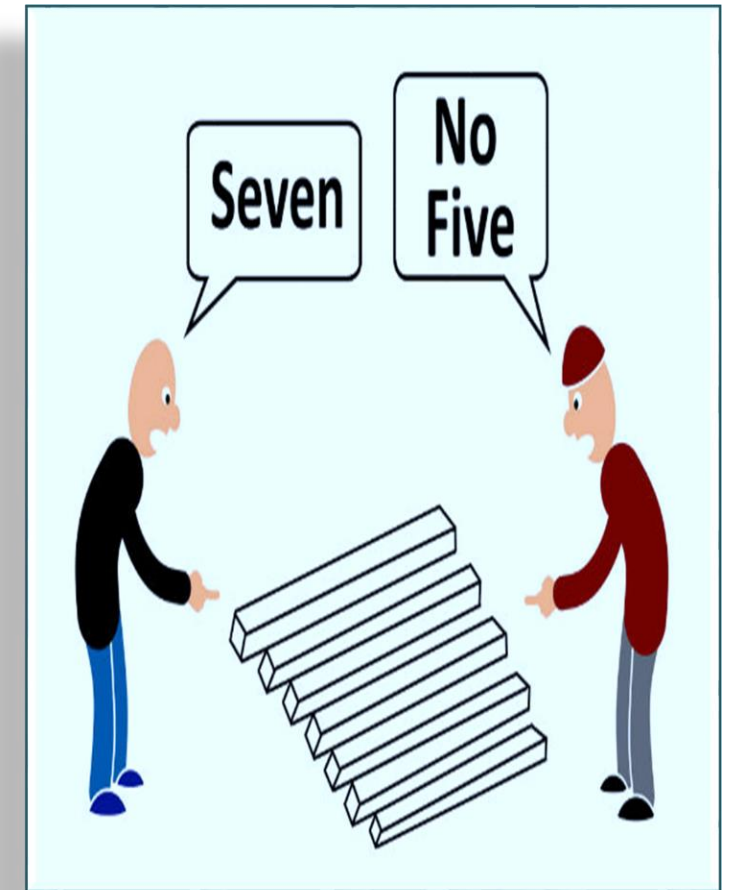
DEPARTMENT OF HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCES



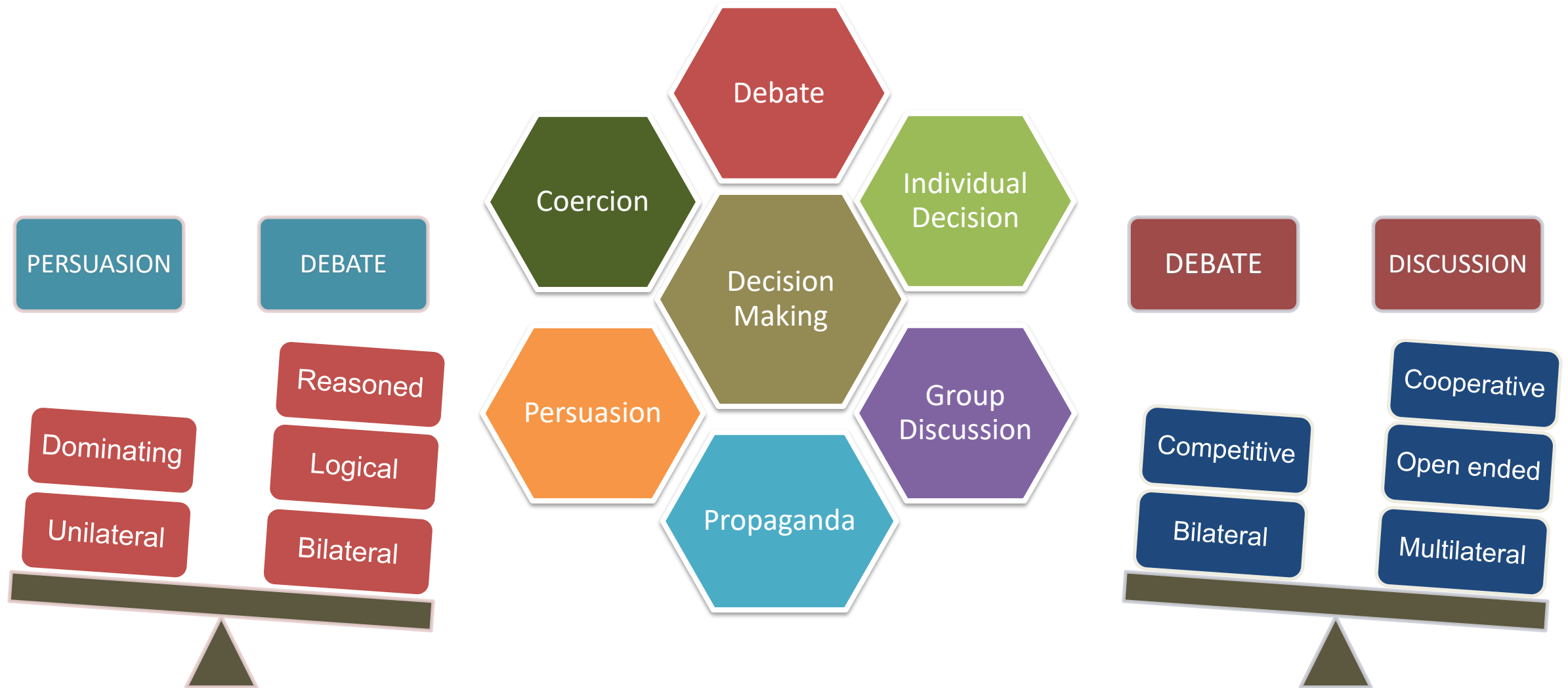
Debate: An Indispensable Art

Debate is a form of public speaking which involves the process of **inquiry** and **argumentation** in order to arrive at a **reasoned judgement** on a **proposition**.

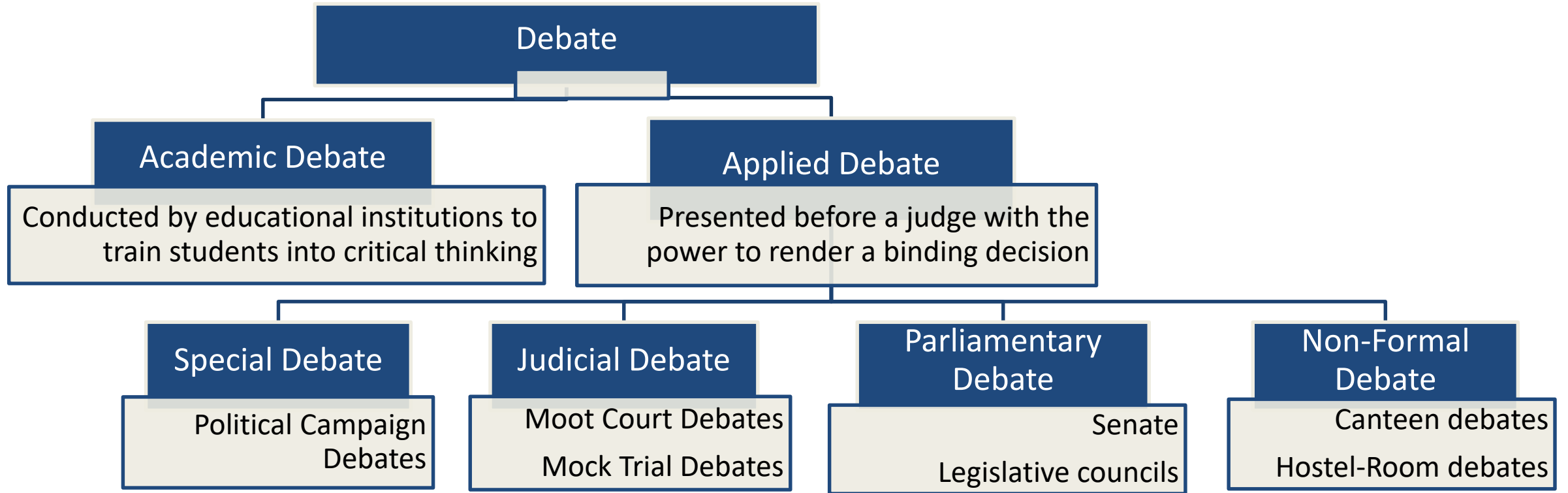
- ❑ An indispensable skill for a democratic society – since majority of its decisions are arrived at by debates in law-courts and legislative bodies.
- ❑ The ancient Greek scholar, **Aristotle**, emphasized the significance of debate in its four functions:
 - It **checks** the triumph of **fraud and injustice**.
 - **Rhetoric**, a crucial component of debate, serves as a **method of instruction** for the society.
 - It generates a **balanced outlook** by making us see both sides of a case.
 - A powerful tool to **safeguard our interests**, freedom and rights in a democratic society.



Methods of Decision Making



Debate: Types



The Debating Process

1. The Debate Proposition

- The debate proposition is a statement that identifies the central issue in a controversy.
- The debate proposition ought to:
 - Clearly state the controversy.
 - Deal with one single significant contemporary idea/problem.
 - Be expressed in a single declarative sentence
 - Avoid ambiguity and emotional terms.
- Debate involves two parties –
 - The **affirmative side**, arguing in favour of the stated proposition.
 - The **negative side**, arguing against the stated proposition.

Phrasing the Debate Proposition

Exploring the Controversy

Researching for Evidence

Corroborating Reasoning

Building the Constructive /
Deconstructive Argument

2. Exploring the Controversy

- For a productive debate, **controversy is an essential prerequisite**. An informed clash of ideas, interests or positions motions the debate towards effective judgement.
- A rigorous enquiry into the controversy involves:
 - ☐ Brainstorming of ideas
 - ☐ Gathering background materials
 - ☐ A critical reading of the sources
 - ☐ Recording materials in an organized form
- The sources for researching into the controversial debate question include :-



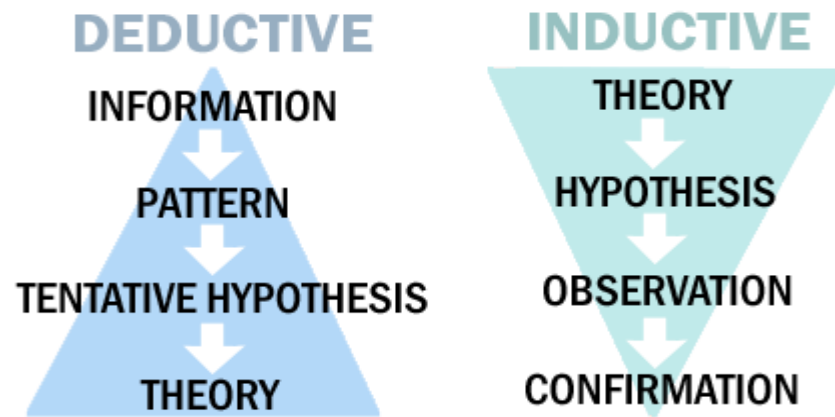
3. **Researching for Evidence** – Evidence consists of facts, opinions, objects and statements that are used as raw materials to validate one's arguments.

☐ Checklist for **evidence credibility**:

- ✓ **Quantity** – There should be enough evidence to support an argument.
- ✓ **Consistent** – One evidence should cohere with other known evidences as well as within itself.
- ✓ **Verifiable** – One must be able to authenticate, confirm and substantiate the evidence.
- ✓ **Fair** – Evidences free from prejudices strengthen ground for arguing one's point.
- ✓ **Competent** – Statistically sound and relevant evidences build a winning case.
- ✓ **Reliable** – Sources of evidence should be trustworthy, accurate and honest.
- ✓ **Acceptable to the audience** – The evidence should be consistent with the beliefs, motives, values and comprehensive standards of the audience.

4. Reasoning: Types

The process of inferring conclusions from the stated premises is termed as reasoning.



Example:

All men are mortal.
(Premise)
Socrates is a man.
(General to Specific)
Socrates is mortal.
(Conclusion)

Example:

Every cat I have seen
had green eyes.
(Specific Case)
Most cats probably
have green eyes.
(Conclusion – Specific
to generalization)

Reasoning by Example

- Inferring conclusion from specific cases

Reasoning by Analogy

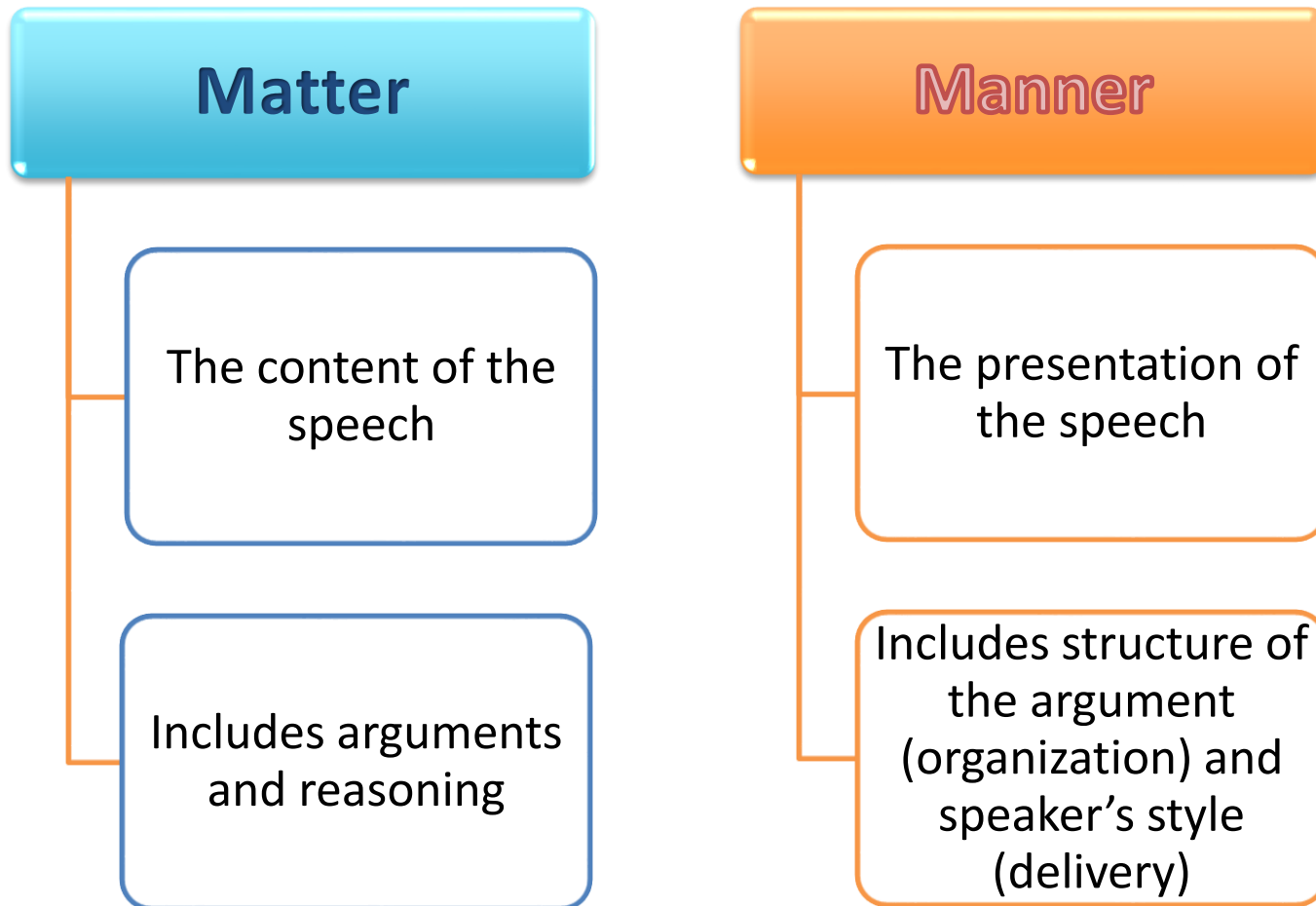
- Comparing two similar cases and inferring that what is true in one case must be true for the other as well

Reasoning by Sign

- Inferring relationship between two closely related variables
- Presence/absence of one may be equated with that of the other

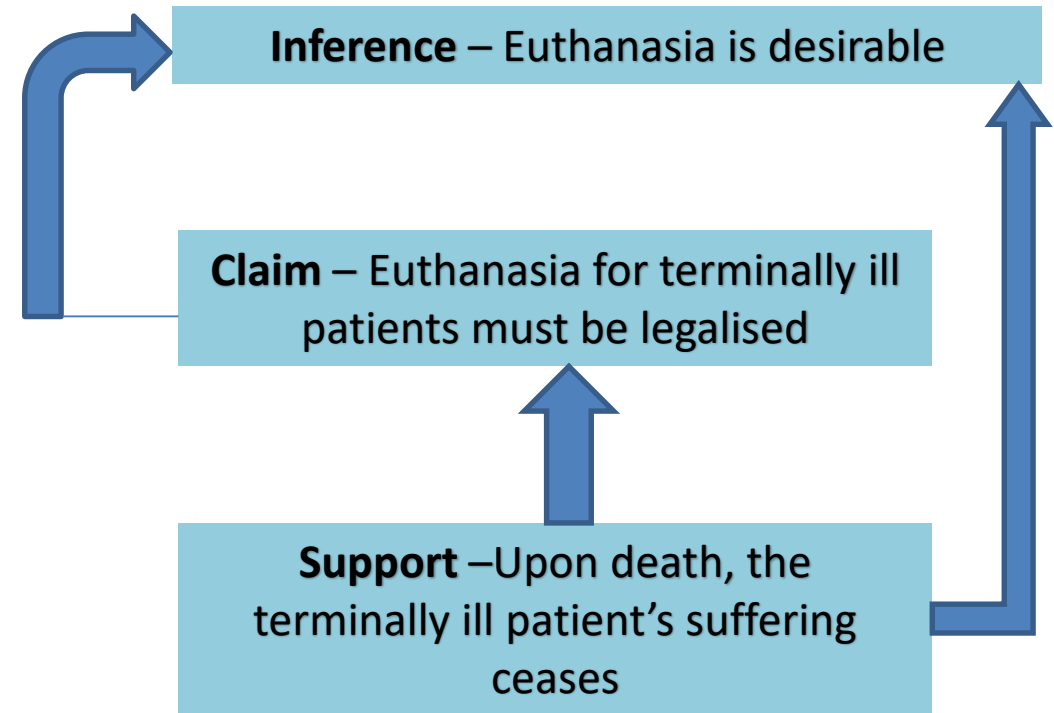
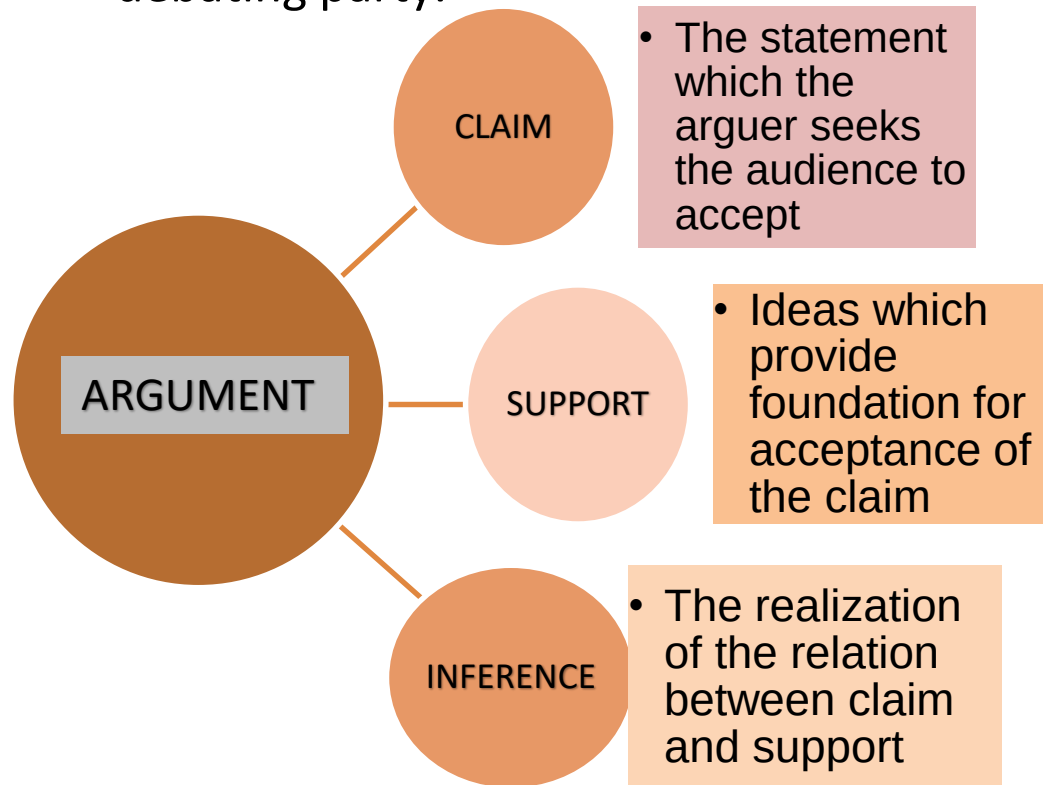
Debate Standards: Matter and Manner

- ❑ Matter and manner are the twin customary criteria foundational for judging the standard of debate.



The Matter: Argument

- ❑ An argument is a collection of statements structurally organized with the purpose of justification of acts, beliefs, attitudes, interests or positions.
- ❑ Argument is the fundamental component of persuasion, which in turn, is the key motive of the debating party.



Fallacies in the Argument

Fallacy of Pseudo-arguments

Arguing in a Circle

Using Popular Appeal

Appealing to Tradition

Baiting an Opponent

Asking Pseudo-question

Substituting Bombast
for Argument

Fallacy of Language

Ambiguity

Verbosity

Complexity

Emotionally Charged

Insensitive to Diversity

Incorrect Grammatical
Structure

Fallacy of Reasoning

Insufficient Evidence

Hasty Generalization

Incorrect Analogy

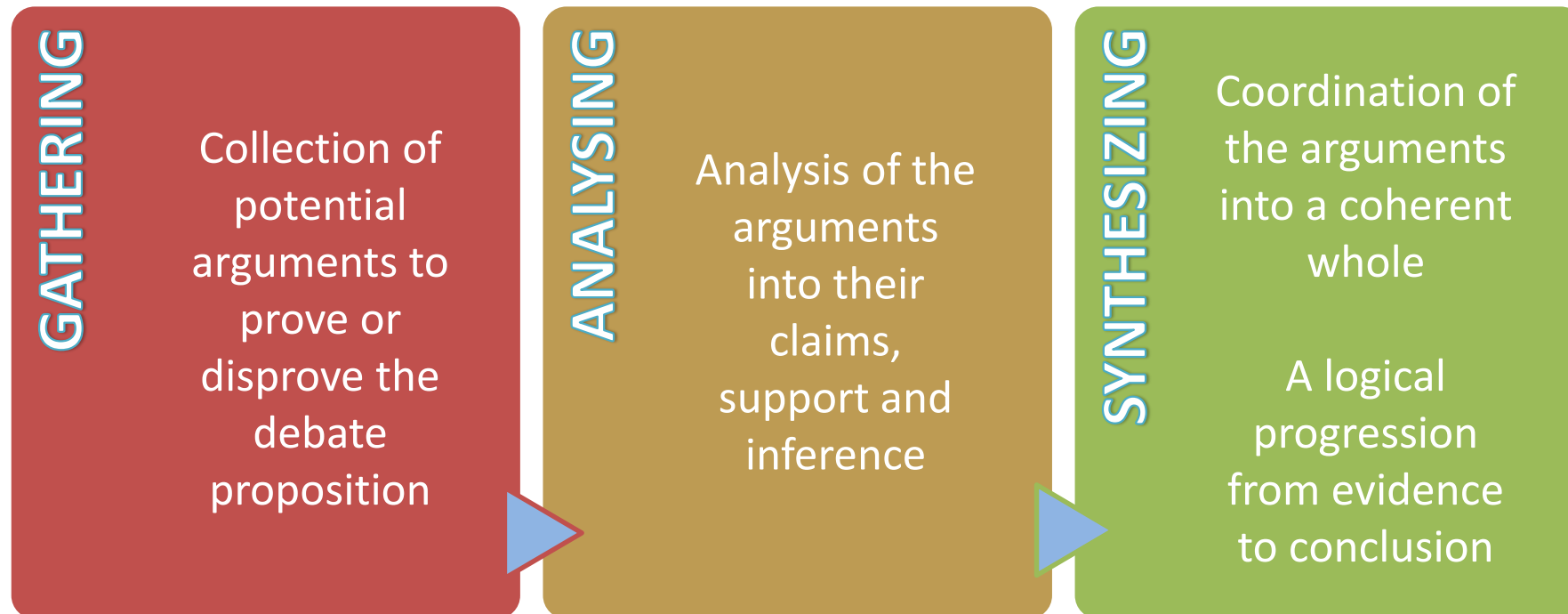
Weak Support for Claim

Prejudiced Approach

Manipulation of Facts
and Figures

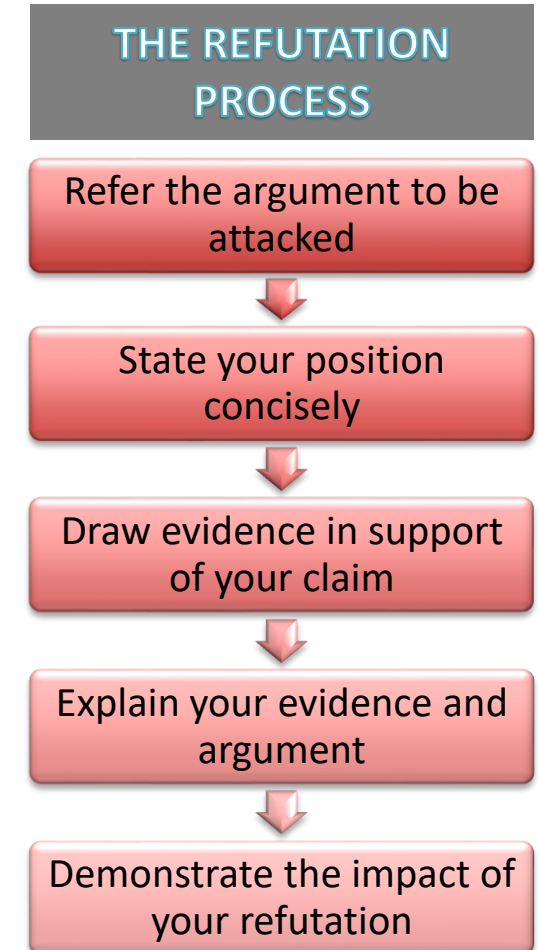
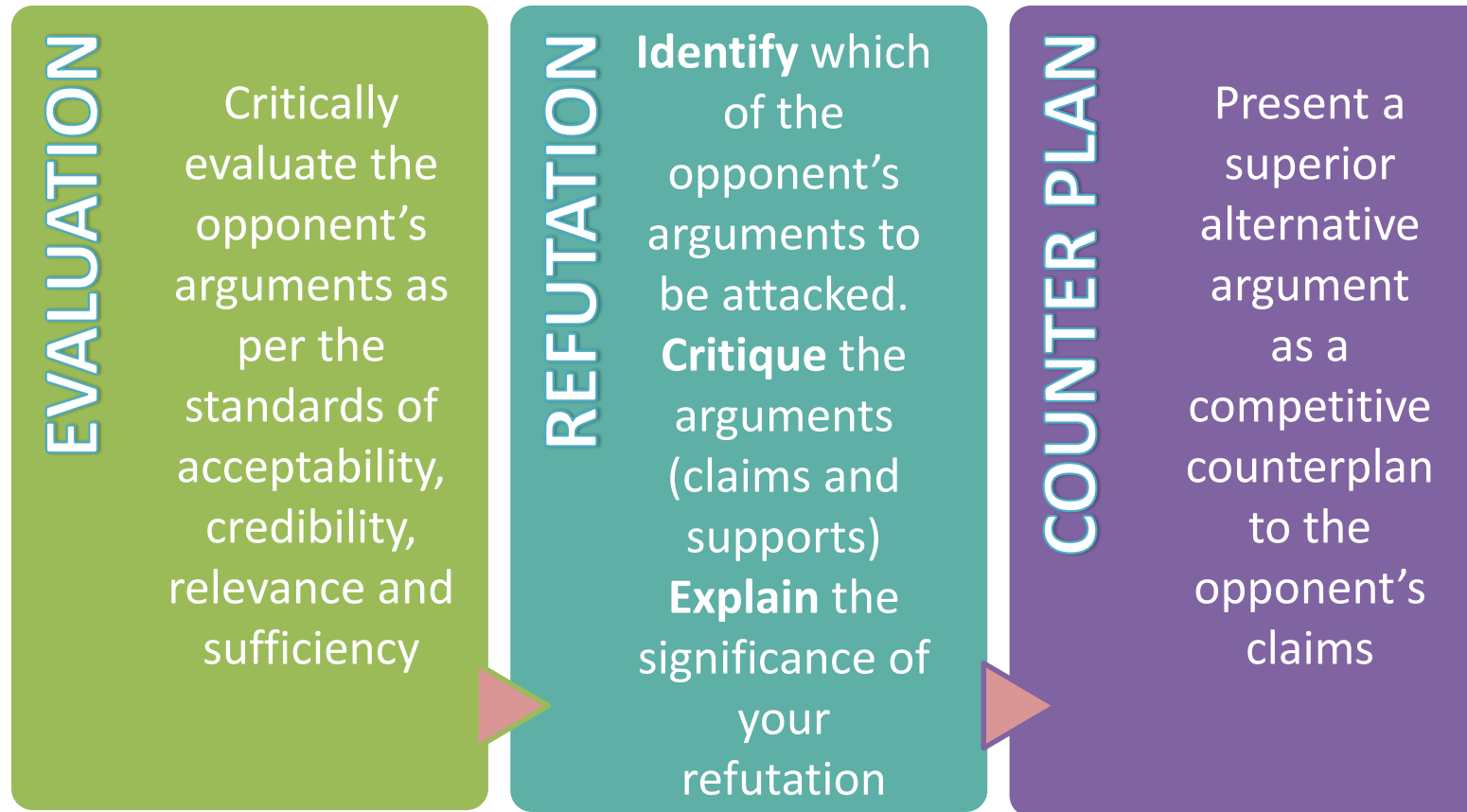
The Matter: Reasoning the Argument

- ❖ **Constructive Argumentation** – Building the arguments favouring your position in the debate proposition.
- ❖ **Steps to Constructive Argumentation:**



The Matter: Reasoning the Argument

- **Deconstructive Argumentation** – Critiquing and refuting the opposition's arguments.
- Steps to Deconstructive Argumentation:



The Manner: Structuring the Argument

- ❖ Well-structured arguments are crucial to effective debating.
- ❖ **Progression:** The arguments should be neatly structured into –
 - **Introduction** – A *preview* that foresees the development of main arguments
 - **Body** – The substance of the argument
 - **Conclusion** – A *review* summarizing the message and providing a definite conclusion
- ❖ **Coherence** – The arguments should feature a clear relationship between what has just been said and what will be said next.
- ❖ **A Definite Order** – The major arguments should be presented in the same order each time they are called in.
- ❖ **Tag-lining** – Repeating an idea consistently and redundantly (for example, through tag-lines) creates an *echo-effect* and helps in cementing the idea in the mind of the audience.
- ❖ **Unity** – The arguments should be bound towards attaining a unified objective, and therefore, exhibit *unity of purpose* and *unity of mood*.
- ❖ **Emphasis** – The weighty argument should be positioned either in the beginning or towards the end for providing greater emphasis.

The Manner: Style of Delivery

CONCISENESS

Be succinct in the expression of ideas
Use powerful and concise words.

CLARITY

Present your case with clarity of thought and jargon-free expressions.

INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE

Use inclusive, non-offensive and culturally appropriate language

APPROPRIATE VOCABULARY

Select the diction of arguments suited to the audience and to the occasion.

SIMPLE and CONCRETE

Use simple structure in sentences
Choose exact words over vague terms.

The Manner: Steps to Good Delivery

NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Vocal Expression

☐ Rate – Moderate

☐ Pitch – Varied

☐ Intensity – Adapted to Occasion

☐ Tone – Flexible

☐ Verbal Fluency

Body Language

☐ Eye Contact – Direct

☐ Movement – Purposeful

☐ Gestures – Aid in Communicating

☐ Facial Expression – Confident

☐ Posture – Relaxed

- ☐ **Speech Outline** – Get ready with a detailed plan of exactly **the content (the ‘what’)** and **the manner (the ‘how’)** of your speech.
- ☐ **Speaker Notes** – Prepare notes in advance for
 - ✓ The key points of your speech
 - ✓ The responses to anticipated arguments of refutation.
 - ✓ Also, record notes from the opponent’s speech for an effective refutation.
- ☐ **Prepare and Practise** – Prepare by building a strong case and rehearse your delivery. Improve upon your presentation by listening to professional speakers.

Dare to Debate – Do's and Don'ts

QUESTIONER

- ☐ Avoid open-ended questions
- ☐ Elicit brief responses
- ☐ Keep questions brief
- ☐ Do not attack the incontestable

RESPONDENT

- ☐ Be on guard
- ☐ Avoid unreasonable questions
- ☐ If you do not know the answer, admit it
- ☐ Do not defend the indefensible

BOTH

- ☐ Conduct with courtesy and professionalism
- ☐ Avoid distracting mannerisms
- ☐ Show passion, sincerity and confidence
- ☐ Prepare and practice



*It is better to debate a question
without settling it than to settle a
question without debating it.*

JOSEPH JOUBERT



Thank You!

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